



DPSH MUN 2026

INTERPOL

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INTERNATIONAL CRIMINAL
POLICE ORGANIZATION



DPSH MUN 2026



AGENDA:

“Enhancing International Cooperation to Combat
Human Trafficking and Migrant Smuggling”

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Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

It is our utmost pleasure to welcome you to the International Criminal Police Organization (INTERPOL) Committee at DPSHMUN '26. We are honoured to serve as your Executive Board and look forward to witnessing an engaging, intellectually stimulating, and solution-oriented committee.

The agenda before this committee -: "Enhancing International Cooperation to Combat Human Trafficking and Migrant Smuggling" addresses one of the most pressing transnational security and humanitarian challenges of the twenty-first century. Every year, millions of individuals become victims of trafficking for purposes including forced labour, sexual exploitation, forced criminality and organ removal, while countless migrants risk dangerous journeys facilitated by sophisticated smuggling networks. These crimes transcend borders, exploit vulnerable populations, generate billions in illicit profits, and continue to evolve alongside technological advancements and geopolitical instability.

Unlike traditional United Nations committees, delegates in INTERPOL represent their respective countries' law enforcement agencies through their National Central Bureaus (NCBs). Consequently, debate should prioritise practical policing strategies, intelligence sharing, investigative cooperation, victim identification, border management, financial investigations and operational coordination rather than political rhetoric or diplomatic posturing. Delegates are encouraged to approach this committee from the perspective of senior law enforcement officials tasked with dismantling organised criminal enterprises while respecting international law, national sovereignty and human rights.

This Background Guide aims to provide delegates with the necessary historical context, legal framework and operational understanding to participate meaningfully in committee. However, it should serve only as a starting point for further independent research. Delegates are expected to familiarise themselves with their country's domestic legislation, existing bilateral and multilateral agreements, and current national policies concerning human trafficking and migrant smuggling.

We encourage every delegate to think critically, negotiate constructively and collaborate effectively throughout the conference. The Executive Board looks forward to a committee characterised by professionalism, creativity and substantive debate.

We wish you the very best in your preparation and eagerly await your participation.

Sincerely,

The Executive Board (INTERPOL)

Introduction to INTERPOL

The International Criminal Police Organization (INTERPOL) is the world's largest international police organisation, facilitating cross-border cooperation among the law enforcement agencies of its 196 member countries. Established in 1923 as the International Criminal Police Commission, INTERPOL was created to ensure that criminals could not evade justice simply by crossing national borders. Following organisational restructuring after the Second World War, the organisation adopted its current name and has since expanded into a global network connecting police authorities across every continent.

Contrary to a widespread misconception, INTERPOL is not an international police force. It possesses neither arrest powers nor investigative jurisdiction within sovereign states. Instead, INTERPOL functions as a coordination and information-sharing organisation, enabling national law enforcement agencies to exchange intelligence, coordinate investigations and provide mutual assistance in combating transnational crime.

Each member country maintains a National Central Bureau (NCB), which acts as the official point of contact between domestic law enforcement agencies and INTERPOL's General Secretariat in Lyon, France. Through these NCBs, countries exchange intelligence, request operational assistance, and coordinate investigations spanning multiple jurisdictions.

One of INTERPOL's most recognised tools is its Notice System. Notices serve as international requests for cooperation rather than legally binding warrants. The most well-known, the Red Notice, requests member countries to locate and provisionally arrest a wanted individual pending extradition, surrender or similar legal action. Other notices facilitate locating missing persons, identifying unidentified bodies, warning member states about dangerous criminals, sharing criminal methodologies and tracing wanted individuals.

INTERPOL also manages one of the world's most comprehensive criminal information systems through its secure global communication platform, I-24/7. This system enables law enforcement agencies to rapidly access databases containing fingerprints, DNA profiles, travel documents, stolen vehicles, firearms, works of art, organised crime intelligence and notices relating to international fugitives.

Within the context of human trafficking and migrant smuggling, INTERPOL's responsibilities include coordinating multinational operations, facilitating intelligence exchange, identifying trafficking networks, supporting victim identification, enhancing border security cooperation and providing specialised training for national police services. While the organisation cannot independently arrest traffickers or prosecute offenders, its ability to connect law enforcement agencies across jurisdictions makes it indispensable in dismantling transnational criminal organisations.

Introduction to the Agenda

The increasing interconnectedness of the modern world has facilitated unprecedented economic growth, international mobility and technological innovation. However, these same developments have also enabled organised criminal groups to expand their operations across national borders. Among the most profitable forms of transnational organised crime are human trafficking and migrant smuggling, crimes that exploit vulnerable populations while generating billions of dollars in illegal revenue annually.

Although often discussed together, human trafficking and migrant smuggling represent distinct criminal activities governed by separate legal frameworks and requiring different law

enforcement responses. Human trafficking is fundamentally a crime against individuals, involving exploitation through force, coercion, deception or abuse of vulnerability. Migrant smuggling, in contrast, primarily concerns the facilitation of illegal entry into a country for financial or material benefit. Nevertheless, the two crimes frequently overlap in practice, with migrants initially smuggled across borders later becoming victims of trafficking.

Numerous global developments have intensified these challenges in recent decades. Armed conflicts, political instability, poverty, climate-induced displacement, economic inequality and restrictive migration policies have increased the number of individuals seeking irregular migration routes. Organised criminal groups have exploited these circumstances by establishing sophisticated international networks capable of recruiting victims online, forging travel documents, laundering illicit profits through complex financial systems and coordinating activities across multiple jurisdictions.

Technological advancements have further transformed these criminal enterprises. Social media platforms, encrypted messaging applications, cryptocurrencies and dark web marketplaces have enabled traffickers and smugglers to recruit victims, advertise illegal services, coordinate logistics and evade law enforcement with increasing sophistication.

Given the transnational nature of these crimes, no single country can effectively combat them in isolation. Success depends upon timely intelligence sharing, coordinated investigations, harmonised legal frameworks, efficient extradition procedures and sustained operational cooperation between national law enforcement agencies. As the primary international platform for police cooperation, INTERPOL occupies a central position in facilitating these efforts.

Delegates must therefore examine not only how individual states can strengthen domestic responses but also how the international law enforcement community can enhance collective action while respecting national sovereignty, human rights and existing international legal obligations.

Mandate and Scope of INTERPOL

The International Criminal Police Organization (INTERPOL) exists to facilitate international police cooperation while respecting the sovereignty and domestic laws of its member countries.

As an intergovernmental organisation, INTERPOL serves as a platform for communication, intelligence exchange and operational coordination rather than as an international law enforcement agency.

INTERPOL does not possess executive policing powers. It cannot arrest individuals, conduct independent investigations, prosecute offenders or compel member states to take specific law enforcement actions. All police powers remain exclusively with the competent national authorities of each member country.

Instead, INTERPOL's mandate includes:

- Facilitating the exchange of criminal intelligence between member states.
- Coordinating multinational investigations into transnational crime.
- Operating secure global police communication systems such as I-24/7.
- Managing international criminal databases containing fingerprints, DNA profiles, travel documents and stolen property.
- Issuing INTERPOL Notices, including Red, Blue, Yellow, Green, Purple, Orange and Black Notices.
- Supporting member states through operational assistance, forensic expertise and specialised training.
- Coordinating international operations targeting organised crime, terrorism, cybercrime, human trafficking and migrant smuggling.

Delegates should also be aware of Article 3 of INTERPOL's Constitution, which states:

"It is strictly forbidden for the Organization to undertake any intervention or activities of a political, military, religious or racial character."

This principle ensures that INTERPOL remains politically neutral and focused solely on criminal law enforcement cooperation.

Consequently, throughout this committee delegates should frame proposals around practical police cooperation, intelligence sharing, victim identification, cross-border investigations, forensic support, capacity building and operational coordination. Proposals involving military intervention, economic sanctions, regime change or political coercion fall outside INTERPOL's mandate and should not form part of committee deliberations.

Human Trafficking: An Overview

Human trafficking is widely recognised as one of the gravest violations of human rights and one of the fastest-growing forms of transnational organised crime. The internationally accepted definition is provided by the Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons, Especially Women and Children (2000), commonly referred to as the Palermo Protocol.

According to this definition, human trafficking involves the recruitment, transportation, transfer, harbouring or receipt of persons through means such as force, coercion, abduction, fraud, deception, abuse of power or exploitation of vulnerability for the purpose of exploitation. Such exploitation includes, but is not limited to, sexual exploitation, forced labour, slavery or practices similar to slavery, servitude and organ removal.

Trafficking can occur both across international borders and entirely within a single country. Consequently, crossing an international border is not a necessary element of the crime. Individuals may be trafficked from one city to another within the same state while remaining victims under international law.

Victims originate from virtually every region of the world, though certain populations remain disproportionately vulnerable. Women and girls continue to comprise a significant proportion of victims identified for sexual exploitation, while men and boys are increasingly identified in cases involving forced labour, construction, agriculture, fishing, mining and manufacturing. Children are particularly susceptible due to poverty, displacement, family instability and limited access to education.

Organised criminal groups frequently exploit humanitarian crises, armed conflicts and natural disasters to identify and recruit vulnerable individuals. False employment opportunities, fraudulent educational programmes, sham marriages and deceptive migration offers are commonly used to lure victims into exploitative situations.

Recent years have witnessed the increasing digitisation of trafficking operations. Criminal groups now employ social media platforms, encrypted communications, online job advertisements and digital payment systems to recruit victims and coordinate trafficking operations while reducing their exposure to traditional policing methods.

The global nature of these networks necessitates an equally coordinated international response involving law enforcement agencies, immigration authorities, financial intelligence units, labour inspectors and victim support organisations.

Migrant Smuggling: An Overview

Migrant smuggling refers to the procurement, for financial or material benefit, of the illegal entry of a person into a state of which that person is neither a national nor a permanent resident. The internationally accepted definition is established by the Protocol against the Smuggling of Migrants by Land, Sea and Air (2000).

Unlike human trafficking, migrant smuggling generally begins with the migrant's voluntary decision to seek transportation across an international border. Individuals often resort to smugglers because of conflict, persecution, poverty, environmental degradation or the absence of safe and legal migration pathways.

Smuggling networks operate through highly organised international structures involving recruiters, transport coordinators, document forgers, corrupt officials, financial facilitators and local guides. Routes frequently span several countries before migrants reach their intended destinations.

The Mediterranean Sea, the Central American corridor, the English Channel, the Sahara Desert and parts of Southeast Asia remain among the world's most active smuggling routes. These journeys frequently expose migrants to severe risks including drowning, suffocation, dehydration, violence, abandonment and exploitation.

Although migrant smuggling itself primarily constitutes a crime against state immigration systems rather than against the migrant, many smuggled migrants subsequently become victims of trafficking, forced labour, debt bondage or other forms of exploitation once they reach transit or destination countries. Consequently, law enforcement responses increasingly recognise the interconnected nature of these offences.

For INTERPOL and national police agencies, combating migrant smuggling requires disrupting criminal enterprises while ensuring that migrants themselves are treated in accordance with international human rights standards and applicable refugee law.

Human Trafficking vs. Migrant Smuggling

Despite frequent public confusion, human trafficking and migrant smuggling constitute legally distinct offences requiring different investigative approaches and policy responses.

The most significant distinction lies in the element of exploitation. Human trafficking is fundamentally centred upon the ongoing exploitation of victims, whereas migrant smuggling primarily involves facilitating illegal border crossings for financial gain. While smuggling generally concludes upon arrival at the intended destination, trafficking often continues through sustained exploitation.

Consent also differs substantially between the two crimes. Smuggled migrants generally consent to transportation, although that consent may arise from desperate circumstances. Victims of trafficking either never consent or any apparent consent becomes legally irrelevant when obtained through coercion, deception, fraud or abuse of vulnerability.

Human trafficking may occur without any international border crossing, whereas migrant smuggling necessarily involves illegal entry into another state.

Law enforcement agencies increasingly recognise that the boundary between these offences is often fluid. Migrants who voluntarily employ smugglers may later experience extortion, forced labour, sexual exploitation or debt bondage, effectively transforming a smuggling operation into a trafficking case. This overlap complicates investigations and requires close coordination between immigration authorities, police services and international organisations.

For INTERPOL, distinguishing between these offences is essential for determining investigative priorities, victim protection measures and appropriate international cooperation mechanisms.

Human trafficking and migrant smuggling continue to evolve in response to shifting geopolitical, economic and technological conditions. Modern criminal organisations operate across multiple jurisdictions, employing increasingly sophisticated methods to recruit victims, transport migrants and conceal illicit profits.

Armed conflicts in regions such as Eastern Europe, the Middle East and parts of Africa have displaced millions of people, significantly increasing vulnerability to trafficking and exploitation. Economic instability, unemployment and widening global inequality have similarly contributed to increased irregular migration and greater demand for smuggling services.

Digital technology has transformed the operational landscape of organised crime. Recruitment increasingly occurs through social media platforms and online employment advertisements, while encrypted messaging applications facilitate communication among criminal networks. Cryptocurrencies and complex financial systems have made illicit profits more difficult to trace, challenging traditional financial investigations.

The COVID-19 pandemic further altered trafficking dynamics by reducing traditional border movements while increasing online exploitation, cyber-enabled recruitment and domestic trafficking. Although international travel has largely resumed, many of these technological adaptations remain central to criminal operations.

Law enforcement agencies also face significant jurisdictional challenges. Differences in domestic legislation, inconsistent investigative capacities, corruption, limited resources and varying evidentiary standards frequently hinder effective international cooperation. Criminal organisations exploit these weaknesses by relocating operations to jurisdictions with weaker enforcement capabilities or limited international coordination.

Finally, balancing effective law enforcement with the protection of victims' rights remains a persistent challenge. Successful responses require not only dismantling criminal networks but also ensuring victim identification, safeguarding survivors from re-victimisation and promoting international cooperation that respects both human rights and national sovereignty.

Role of Transnational Organized Crime Networks

- What are Transnational Organized Crime Networks?

According to the United Nations, transnational Organized Crime Networks (TOCNs) are structured groups that operate across national borders to carry out illegal activities for financial or material gain. Operating across national borders, these networks exploit weak governance, corruption, poorly secured borders, differences in domestic legislation, and limited international cooperation to evade law enforcement and expand their operations. Human trafficking and migrant smuggling are among their most profitable criminal activities, posing significant threats to global security, stability, and sustainable development. Unlike local criminal groups, TOCNs possess extensive logistical capabilities, financial networks, and secure communication channels, enabling them to plan, coordinate, and execute operations across multiple countries.

- Organized crime groups benefit from:

- Continuous demand for cheap labour and commercial sexual exploitation.
- Vulnerable populations affected by poverty, conflict, disasters, and displacement.
- Limited international coordination in investigations and prosecutions.
- The ability to exploit online platforms for recruitment and communication.
- Relatively low conviction rates in many jurisdictions.

International Legal and Institutional Framework

Recognising that human trafficking and migrant smuggling cannot be addressed by individual states alone, the international community has developed a comprehensive legal framework to promote cooperation while protecting victims' rights.

The cornerstone of this framework is the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (UNTOC), adopted in 2000. The Convention provides a common legal framework for countries to cooperate in preventing, investigating, and prosecuting transnational organized crime. It is supplemented by two key protocols: the Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons, Especially Women and Children (Palermo Protocol) and the Protocol against the Smuggling of Migrants by Land, Sea and Air. Together, these instruments provide internationally recognised definitions of trafficking and smuggling while encouraging States to criminalise these offences, strengthen border management, protect victims and cooperate in cross-border investigations.

International organizations also help countries implement these legal frameworks through practical support and cooperation. INTERPOL helps police forces from different countries share information and coordinate investigations. The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) provides training, technical assistance, and support for implementing international laws against organized crime. The International Organization for Migration (IOM) works to protect migrants, assist victims of trafficking, and promote safe and orderly migration. Together, these organizations strengthen international cooperation and support countries in preventing, investigating, and responding to human trafficking and migrant smuggling..

Alongside UNTOC and its Protocols, several international human rights treaties reinforce efforts to combat human trafficking and migrant smuggling. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) affirms the right to life, liberty, and security and prohibits slavery and servitude. The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR) further prohibits forced labour and arbitrary deprivation of liberty.

The Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) requires States to protect children from all forms of exploitation, while the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) calls upon States to suppress trafficking in women and the exploitation of prostitution. Together, these instruments ensure that efforts to combat trafficking and smuggling remain grounded in the protection of human rights and the dignity of victims.

INTERPOL's Role in Combating Human Trafficking and Migrant Smuggling

As the world's largest international police organization, INTERPOL plays a vital role in helping its 196 member countries cooperate against human trafficking and migrant smuggling. Since these crimes often involve multiple countries, INTERPOL facilitates the exchange of information, coordination of investigations, and operational support between national law enforcement agencies.

Unlike national police forces, INTERPOL does not have the authority to make arrests or conduct independent investigations. Instead, it supports member countries through tools such as the I-24/7 secure global communication system, which enables real-time intelligence sharing, and the INTERPOL Notices system, which helps locate fugitives, identify victims and missing persons, and support cross-border investigations.

INTERPOL also coordinates multinational operations, provides criminal intelligence and forensic support, delivers specialized training, and works closely with organizations such as UNODC and IOM. By strengthening international police cooperation and intelligence sharing, INTERPOL helps member countries detect, investigate, and dismantle transnational trafficking and migrant smuggling networks.

Key Challenges to International Cooperation

Despite growing international cooperation, several challenges continue to hinder efforts to combat human trafficking and migrant smuggling. Differences in national laws and legal procedures can make cross-border investigations and extradition difficult. Limited intelligence

sharing, lack of resources, and varying law enforcement capacities also reduce the effectiveness of joint operations.

Corruption, weak border management, and political instability further enable criminal networks to operate across borders with minimal risk. In addition, traffickers increasingly use encrypted communication platforms, social media, and cryptocurrencies, making it more difficult for authorities to detect and investigate their activities.

Another major challenge is ensuring that victims are identified and protected. Many victims are mistakenly treated as irregular migrants or offenders, preventing them from accessing the support and justice they need. Addressing these challenges requires stronger international cooperation, greater information sharing, and a victim-centred approach to law enforcement.

Rapid technological advancements have created new challenges for law enforcement. Criminal networks increasingly use encrypted messaging platforms, social media, artificial intelligence, and cryptocurrencies to recruit victims, coordinate operations, and transfer illicit funds. For example, trafficking syndicates have used fake online job advertisements and social media platforms to lure victims with false promises of employment abroad, making detection more difficult.

Humanitarian crises and armed conflicts have also increased the vulnerability of displaced populations. Recent conflicts in Ukraine and Sudan, along with the growth of online scam compounds in Southeast Asia, have demonstrated how criminal networks exploit people fleeing violence or seeking employment. Many victims have been trafficked into forced labour, sexual exploitation, or cyber-enabled scam operations.

Another major challenge is ensuring that victims are identified and protected. Victims are often misidentified as irregular migrants or offenders, preventing them from receiving legal protection, rehabilitation, and access to justice. Addressing these challenges requires stronger international cooperation, timely intelligence sharing, improved use of technology, and a victim-centred approach that places equal importance on prosecuting offenders and protecting those affected.

Contemporary Case Studies and Recent Development

Recent developments show that human trafficking and migrant smuggling are becoming more sophisticated, requiring stronger international cooperation and coordinated law enforcement responses.

One significant trend is the rise of technology enabled trafficking. Criminal networks increasingly use social media, encrypted messaging applications, and fake online job advertisements to recruit victims across borders. Artificial intelligence and deepfake technology have also been used to create false identities and fraudulent documents, making investigations more complex.

Another major concern is the emergence of online scam compounds in Southeast Asia, particularly in parts of Myanmar, Cambodia, and Laos. Thousands of individuals have been trafficked under the false promise of legitimate employment and forced to operate online investment, cryptocurrency, and romance scams. These cases highlight the growing connection between human trafficking, cybercrime, and transnational organized crime.

Ongoing humanitarian crises have also heightened the risk of trafficking. Conflicts in Ukraine, Sudan, and parts of the Middle East have displaced millions of people, leaving many vulnerable to exploitation, forced labour, and sexual trafficking. Criminal networks often target displaced persons who lack financial resources, legal documentation, or access to protection.

In response to these evolving threats, INTERPOL, in collaboration with member countries and international organizations such as UNODC and IOM, has coordinated multinational operations to identify victims, dismantle trafficking networks, and strengthen intelligence sharing. These developments highlight the importance of international cooperation, information exchange, and coordinated law enforcement efforts in addressing human trafficking and migrant smuggling.

Areas for Deliberation

In addressing this agenda, nations should focus on practical measures that strengthen international cooperation while remaining within INTERPOL's mandate. Discussions should emphasize improving coordination between national law enforcement agencies to prevent, investigate, and dismantle transnational trafficking and migrant smuggling networks. Key areas for deliberation include enhancing intelligence sharing through INTERPOL's communication systems, strengthening joint cross border investigations, improving border security while protecting the rights of migrants and trafficking victims, and using emerging technologies to detect and disrupt criminal activities. As trafficking and migrant smuggling continue to evolve, delegates should consider innovative, collaborative, and victim centred approaches that enhance international police cooperation while respecting national sovereignty, human rights, and international law.

Questions a Resolution Must Answer

To effectively address the agenda, delegates should consider the following questions during their research and committee discussions:

- Why do human trafficking and migrant smuggling require international cooperation rather than action by individual countries alone?
- What are the biggest challenges faced by countries in combating these crimes across borders?
- How can INTERPOL improve intelligence sharing and coordination among its member countries?
- What role should technology play in detecting and preventing trafficking and migrant smuggling while respecting privacy and human rights?
- How can countries strengthen border security without compromising the rights and safety of migrants and trafficking victims?
- What measures can be taken to improve victim identification, protection, rehabilitation, and reintegration?
- How can international organizations such as INTERPOL, UNODC, and IOM work together more effectively?
- What practical steps can member countries take to dismantle transnational organized crime networks and prevent these crimes from recurring?